

SEARCHING FOR THE **PUNCHLINE** IN PARIS

Indian boxers will get two chances, in World Qualification Tournaments 1 and 2, from February 29 to March 12 and May 23 to June 3, respectively, **to win quota places** for the Paris Olympics.

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In a productive 2023 calendar, Indian women boxers, who secured four world titles, four Asian Games medals, and four Olympic quota places, fared better than their male counterparts and held promise in the Olympic year.

The women began in style, claiming four gold medals in the World Championships held in Delhi. Nikhat Zareen raised her profile by earning a second consecutive world crown, this time in the 50kg weight category, after her maiden title in 52kg in Istanbul in 2022. Tokyo Olympic bronze medallist Lovlina Borgohain reaffirmed her dominance in the heavier 75kg weight class by adding the World Championships gold to her Asian Championships crown.

Saweety Boora upgraded her silver medal from 2014 to complete a sensational performance from the host, while former world youth champion Nitu Ghangas pocketed her first World Championship gold medal in 48kg.

The Indian women showed their prowess once again, this time at the

Asian Games, as they bagged a silver (Lovlina, 75 kg) and three bronze medals (Nikhat, 50 kg, Preeti Pawar, 54 kg, and Parveen Hooda, 57 kg). All four booked their tickets to the Paris Olympics as well.

Young Preeti impressed by registering some upset wins in the World Championships and followed it up with a medal in Hangzhou. Parveen, a 63kg bronze medallist in the 2022 World Championships, lost six kg to shine in a lighter weight.

Meanwhile, the Indian male boxers had a decent year. They won three bronze medals at the World Championships in Tashkent, Uzbekistan.

The promising duo of Deepak Bhorla (51kg), who lived up to his reputation of being a giant killer, and the young Nishant Dev (71kg), who beat a Cuban boxer in a World Championship — a rare occurrence for an Indian boxer — produced some spectacular performances. The experienced and technically sound Mohammad Hussamuddin (57kg) finally made his presence felt at the highest level by climbing the podium.

But the Indian men's showing dipped in the Asian Games. Only Narender Berwal (+92kg) managed a

bronze medal, while none could win an Olympic quota place.

Hussamuddin's left knee injury at the World Championships was a big setback. Indian boxing lovers would hope for his timely recovery from the surgery and his return to form ahead of the Olympics, as the seasoned boxer is capable of securing a ticket to Paris.

As the sole focus in 2024 will be on qualifying for the Olympics and doing well there, efforts will be made to earn two remaining quota places in the women's section and gather as many as possible in the men's section.

In the Tokyo Olympics, India sent nine entries, and the Boxing Federation of India (BFI) would like to see at least a matching number of entries this time and a better showing than just one bronze medal.

Meanwhile, the much-debated assessment system, introduced by high-performance director Bernard Dunne in place of the old selection trials to pick boxers for big events, was under the scanner, with several boxers moving court. It is another matter that they did not get any favourable verdicts.

The new system, under which the